

Image 1.2: Map of Maharaja Ranjit Singh's Sikh Empire
Source: Archives of AIM Television Pvt. Ltd.

The Maharaja allowed Gulab Singh complete autonomy over his own army.[6] Their special relationship intensified in 1823 when the Maharaja granted Jammu to Gulab Singh as a hereditary principality.[7] The Maharaja, enamoured by Gulab Singh's brother Dhyan Singh, bestowed the province of Poonch to Dhyan Singh as a hereditary principality as well. In later years, Dhyan Singh would become the Prime Minister of the Sikh Empire.

Sikh governors were employed in the valley of Kashmir to administer the adjoining region. In 1834, Gulab Singh's forces, led by the dynamic Gen. Zorawar Singh, captured Ladakh[8]and the ruling Maharaja was exiled to the village of Stok near Leh.

After Maharaja Ranjit Singh's death in 1839, Zorawar Singh conquered Baltistan and Gilgit. In 1841, his army extended the Sikh Empire till Gartok, near the source of the Indus, and to Lake Mansarovar. In December